

Ms Kavita Shirvaikar: A Turnaround Specialist Redefining Indian Infrastructure



A Legacy Reimagined: The Resurgence of Patel Engineering

In the high-stakes theatre of Indian infrastructure, few stories are as compelling as the turnaround of Patel Engineering Ltd (PEL). As India gears up for the Union Budget 2026, the 75-year-old firm stands not just as a survivor of the industry's debt-heavy past, but as a vanguard of its specialized, sustainable future. At the centre of this metamorphosis is Ms. Kavita Shirvaikar, the Managing Director whose tenure marks a shift from engineering-only focus to a sophisticated marriage of technical brilliance and fiscal discipline.

The Architect of the Turnaround

When Ms. Shirvaikar joined PEL, the company was grappling with a

formidable debt mountain of approximately ₹5,500 crore a by-product of a volatile infrastructure cycle. A Chartered Accountant by training, Shirvaikar brought a "back-to-basics" financial rigor that has since become the company's North Star. Through a disciplined mix of strategic debt restructuring, non-core asset monetization, and a relentless focus on settling arbitration claims via schemes like Vivad Se Vishwas, she has successfully whittled the debt down to ₹1,543.2 crore as of Q2 FY26.

Under her leadership, the Debt-to-Equity ratio has plummeted to a lean 0.4, a rarity for a heavy civil construction firm. This financial sobriety has allowed PEL to reclaim its position as a preferred partner for the nation's

most complex projects.

Engineering the "Inner Line"

While the balance sheet was being rebuilt, the engineering teams were conquering horizons. PEL's niche hydropower, complex tunneling, and irrigation acts as a protective moat against commoditized competition. The company's footprint is visible in India's most strategic geographies. From the Sela Tunnel in Arunachal Pradesh, providing all-weather connectivity at 13,000 feet, to the US-BRL rail link in Jammu & Kashmir, PEL is literally carving the paths of national security and regional integration.

Currently, the firm commands over 50% of the total hydropower capacity under development in India. Projects like the 2,000 MW Lower Subansiri Hydroelectric Project are not just power plants; they are the "green batteries" essential for the nation's transition to a non-fossil future.

The Pre-Budget Perspective: Advocacy for Growth

As the Union Budget approaches, Ms. Shirvaikar views the government's Capex push not just as a revenue opportunity, but as a catalyst for systemic reform.

She advocates for a budget that incentivizes modern construction technologies and streamlines the dispute resolution process, ensuring that liquidity remains within the project ecosystem. For Ms. Shirvaikar, the goal is to transform Patel Engineering into a platform that doesn't just build assets, but accelerates the national multiplier effect turning every kilometer of tunnel and every megawatt of power into a building block for an equitable, \$5-trillion economy.